



Strictly speaking, economically, India smells of roses. Yes, inflation is still running high and GDP growth may slow down to 6 per cent, but in a world that is staring at a crisis, this is an enviable position to be in

oped' country. Commentators who celebrate the country's improvement on cherry-picked social parameters—and finally it is the quality of life of most citizens that makes a country great, or not—have probably never been to an Indian village. The recent ranking of India in the UN Human Development Index (HDI), 132 out of 191 countries and down over the last two years, is a timely reminder. A country with that low a human development rank cannot be called a developed nation, no matter what its GDP growth is. On the margin, some parameters may be improving, but the pace is glacial. And these small bits of progress are

offset by the stark decline in social and communal cohesion that is visible in everyday life. It is all very good to talk about our remarkable strides in digital adoption, but the floods in Bengaluru and the (inevitably) looming pollution scare in Delhi in winter are a reminder that there are miles to go before India can claim to have the infrastructure of a truly great city. Jingoism aside, anyone who has ever been to London, New York or Singapore would be blind to assert that India has the equivalent of even one truly global capital, swank airports and the 'spirit of Mumbai' notwithstanding. The less said of our soft infrastructure—edu-

cation, healthcare and general civic standards—the better.

India is a work in progress. Blessed as it is with a strong domestic economic base thanks to demographics, it still has to build on that to create a truly world-class economy and society. It is easy to gloat at the misfortunes of others and adopt an air of superiority, where what needs doing is to knuckle down on fixing our own flaws. Climbing the GDP charts may make India the toast of Davos, but till we succeed in making our society and economy more inclusive, civil and humane, at heart, we will always know that we are not there, yet. **BT**